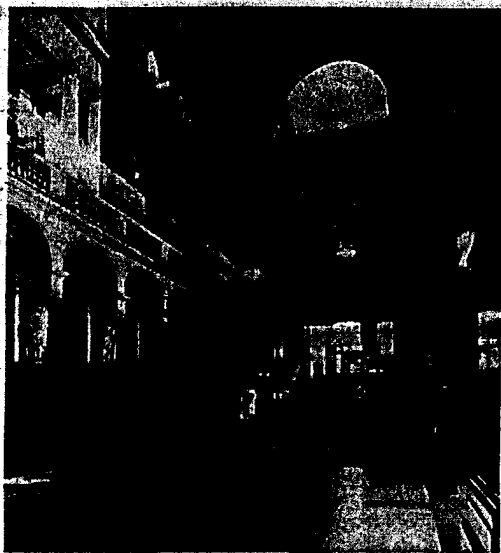




COURTLY SURROUNDINGS—Imposing interior of the Suffolk County Courthouse at Pemberton square.

Boston needs a *real* Landmark Commission

ARCHITECTURE / By ROBERT CAMPBELL

The building in the illustration is presented as a symbol — a symbol of Boston's rapidly vanishing past, and of the fact that not an awful lot is being done to preserve it.

The building is the Suffolk County Courthouse — not an architectural masterpiece, but a building with the kind of real character that seldom seems to accrue to today's government buildings, many of them apparently designed by the man who did Hitler's bunker.

Right next door to the courthouse, for example, government estheticians are in process of constructing an exact, loving copy

of one of Boston's worst buildings, the ungainly and airless Leverett Saltonstall State Office Building.

The Saltonstall Building is to architecture what R. H. Haldeman is to statesmanship, but that hasn't stopped Government Center Commission planners from erecting its hulking, faceless twin right on the border of the delicate and vulnerable Beacon Hill national historic district.

With neighbors like these, the old Suffolk courthouse can only look good. And it recently got a

new lease on life when City Hall Plaza was extended up a broad staircase beneath One Center Plaza and into Pemberton Square, now redesigned as a fine urban space that sets off the old courthouse with real dignity.

Yet the building is in danger. New courtrooms are required, and the existing building, say critics, is antiquated — although reputable studies indicate that, with renovations, the courthouse can continue to serve until the year 2000.

What would replace Suffolk Courthouse if it

were torn down? Your nightmare is as good as mine, but it's a safe bet that the bureaucracy that gave us two Saltonstall buildings wouldn't balk at a third.

Why preserve old buildings at all? Is there really any point? Many people don't seem to see any. Yet there are some basic issues at stake.

What was built in the past is what makes one city, one neighborhood different from another. Where Boston was brick, New York was brownstone; where Dorchester is

three-deckers, Beacon Hill is row houses.

In today's highly homogenized, worldwide culture, there isn't much that makes us different from people in say, Flint, Michigan — we have the same cars, the same TV shows, the same Kentucky fried chicken. Preserving the past means preserving a sense of difference, a vestige of individual identity. It's a holding action until the day when we get enough control over our own technology to be able again to express a sense of place in our buildings.

Then, too, older neighborhoods have specifically architectural lessons. When buildings were built by hand, they had a human scale. When they got to be skyscrapers, made from factory parts, they lost their scale. You can't repeat a window 6000 times and end up with a humane building. What you end up with, in fact, is the Leverett Saltonstall Building. We need the older buildings to help set standards.

Not everyone accepts this. Often, a developer will argue that an old building should be torn down to make way for a new high-rise because the old building isn't "economic", because the new building will provide a better "tax base." And it's true that a new John Hancock tower in the middle of Louisburg Square would increase the tax yield of its parcel, if that parcel is all you look at. But when a neighborhood or a city loses its character, it also begins to lose its market value. We have to start making our economic evaluations not in terms of single parcels but of whole cities.

Probably few Bostonians will believe it, but this city is far behind other American cities on the preservation issue. New York, San Francisco, Denver, Chicago and a host of others have Landmark Commissions

holding public hearings, listing buildings and neighborhoods for preservation. A growing body of legal precedent is accumulating, including such innovations as tax concessions to owners of unprofitable landmark buildings, displacement of the landmark site's air rights to another parcel, etc.

Boston has a Landmark Commission too, set up in 1969 as an adjunct of the BRA. But the Commission is pure window dressing in its present form, with no legal power to do anything.

What is frustrating is that a law exists that would give the Landmark Commission the independence it needs. This law has been in draft form for more than a year. All it needs is an endorsement from Mayor White to go before the city council. No one seems to know quite why this endorsement has not yet been forthcoming.

A strong Landmark Commission wouldn't step on anyone's toes. The legal safeguards — hearings, appeals — are built in. What it would do is give us the means, if we wanted it, to preserve some of our heritage. The Mayor should act.